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UPSC Civil Services Examination: planning reference

Prepared: October 2026. Current official notices still require verification.

Verification status: Live official content could not be retrieved in this environment. Requests to the official sites listed below failed at the network proxy with `Tunnel connection failed: 403 Forbidden`; an HTTP request to UPSC also returned HTTP 403. These responses do not establish that the websites themselves are down. The exam structure below is a high-confidence summary of the established CSE scheme, **not a verified transcription of the latest notification**. The official notification and corrigenda for the candidate's actual examination year take precedence.

This public guide does not determine any individual candidate’s eligibility or assign an attempt year.

1. What the examination tests

The process has a screening stage, a written examination, and a personality test. Knowing facts helps, but comprehension, reasoning, clear written arguments, judgment, and revision also matter. These are trainable skills. School marks or a learner's description of their intelligence do not establish their ability to prepare.

Stage	Established scheme	Implication for preparation
Preliminary examination, General Studies Paper I	200 marks; objective questions; ordinarily 2 hours	Cover the official GS syllabus and practise eliminating incorrect choices. Selection for Mains depends on the applicable GS I cutoff after qualifying Paper II.
Preliminary examination, General Studies Paper II (CSAT)	200 marks; objective questions; ordinarily 2 hours; qualifying at 33%	Practise reading comprehension, basic numeracy, data interpretation, and reasoning from the beginning. A qualifying paper can still prevent qualification.
Mains qualifying papers	Paper A, an Indian language, 300 marks; Paper B, English, 300 marks	These do not contribute to the final ranking, but qualifying requirements and any Paper A exemption must be checked.
Mains papers counted for merit	Essay 250; GS I–IV 250 each; optional subject Papers I–II 250 each	Seven papers total **1,750 marks**. Learn to construct and write answers as well as recognise MCQ answers.
Personality test	**275 marks**	Knowledge, balanced judgment, clarity, and personal background require preparation.
Final merit total	**2,025 marks** from counted Mains papers plus personality test	Prelims marks do not add to the final merit total.

In the established preliminary scheme, a wrong answer ordinarily loses **one third of the marks assigned to that question**. An unanswered question attracts no penalty. Marking more than one answer is ordinarily treated as incorrect, even if one marked answer is correct. Check the applicable year's instructions and accommodations.

The qualifying language papers have historically required 25% in each applicable paper. **Paper A exemptions are specific**, including provisions for candidates hailing from certain northeastern states and certain candidates with benchmark hearing disability under prescribed conditions. Do not infer an exemption merely from a preferred language, a broad disability label, or residence. Read the current notification's complete exemption conditions. English Paper B and language-of-answer rules are separate issues.

2. Syllabus map, simplified

This map supports planning and does not replace the official syllabus.

- **Prelims GS I:** national and international current events; Indian history and the national movement; Indian/world geography; polity and governance; economic and social development; environment, ecology, biodiversity and climate change; general science.
- **CSAT:** comprehension; interpersonal/communication skills as specified in the syllabus; logical reasoning and analytical ability; decision-making/problem-solving; general mental ability; basic numeracy and data interpretation at approximately Class X level.
- **Mains GS I:** Indian heritage/culture, history, geography, and society.
- **Mains GS II:** Constitution, polity, governance, social justice, and international relations.
- **Mains GS III:** economy, agriculture, science/technology, environment, disaster management, and security.
- **Mains GS IV:** ethics, integrity, and aptitude, including case studies.
- **Essay:** coherent, relevant, balanced extended writing.
- **Optional subject:** two papers in one permitted subject. Choose after reviewing the official syllabus and actual previous papers, rather than based solely on popularity.

3. Eligibility: collect facts before deciding

If you have not yet enrolled in a degree: choosing a recognised bachelor's route is an important planning step alongside introductory UPSC study. Class XII alone does not meet the usual CSE degree requirement. Do not calculate an earliest eligible attempt from a course label alone: confirm the programme, admission session, degree-award requirements, academic results/proof timing, and the applicable examination rules. Check each recruitment's age cutoff using your exact birth date privately.

The usual general-category framework has been a recognised graduate degree or accepted equivalent, age **21–32** on the prescribed cutoff date (normally 1 August of the examination year), and **six attempts**. This is **not a personal eligibility determination or a promise that future rules will be identical**.

Category, benchmark disability status, nationality, date of birth, degree status, and previous attempts can change the answer. OBC and SC/ST provisions differ from general-category provisions; additional relaxations and documentary requirements apply to some candidates. IAS, IPS, and Indian Foreign Service nationality requirements must not be assumed identical to every service covered by the CSE.

Candidates awaiting results or intending to take the qualifying examination have historically had a conditional route under the notice's academic-qualification provisions. **There is no blanket CSE eligibility rule saying that being in the second year of a three-year degree is sufficient.** The decisive questions are

whether the candidate satisfies that examination year's degree/conditional qualifying-examination requirements and can provide the required proof by its specified deadline. A college year label alone does not answer either question. The precise stage and document deadline must be read from the applicable examination-year notification; neither a DAF stage nor the interview stage is assumed here. Actually appearing in even one Prelims paper ordinarily counts as an attempt; merely applying ordinarily does not.

Choose a degree you can complete and use

There is no general CSE requirement to take engineering or a particular arts subject. A recognised BA, BSc, BCom, engineering degree, or another eligible bachelor's route can satisfy the usual degree framework; the actual award and recognition still need checking. Degree choice should consider interests, affordability, language, schedule, admissions requirements, support, and useful career options beyond this examination. A BA may overlap with parts of the syllabus, but is not compulsory or automatically the best choice.

Before paying an admission fee:

1. Use **UGC** records and the university's official prospectus to check the awarding institution's recognition/status and its authority to offer the chosen programme. For an affiliated college, also confirm affiliation for that programme and session with the awarding university. Check any additional professional-regulator requirements relevant to the programme.
2. For **open/distance or online** study, use **UGC-DEB** records to verify the exact **institution + programme + mode + admission session**. A university appearing in a list does not by itself establish that every online or distance programme it advertises is recognised for every session. Follow any current official admission/learner-registration requirements shown there.
3. Read the official programme regulations: entry conditions, examinations, attendance or contact sessions, assessment, fees, awarding institution, and which completed credits/years produce an actual **bachelor's degree**. A certificate or diploma exit award is not automatically a graduate degree.
4. Check whether this specific programme and intended award take three years, four years, or another applicable period; do not infer duration from a course label. Record expected completion only after an actual admission route is selected, and allow for exam/result schedules.
5. Once an examination year is realistic, compare the degree completion/proof timing with that year's UPSC notification and check age/attempt limits. Begin study now without promising an immediate application or an assumed graduation year.

Information a mentor eventually needs, without collecting identity documents or certificate numbers:

1. Intended examination year, if one is already chosen.
2. Current degree status or route under consideration; confirmed admission/session and expected completion date when available.
3. Age at the official cutoff when assessing a specific notice. Use exact DOB privately if needed; do not add it to routine public or portable learning records.
4. Nationality and applicable reservation/relaxation category, only if the learner wishes eligibility to be assessed.
5. Number of previous CSE Prelims appearances.
6. Study language and comfort with basic English, mathematics, and writing.

None of these facts needs to delay introductory learning.

Recruitment while completing the degree

If you want to consider recruitment for which Class XII may be sufficient, investigate **SSC CHSL** and relevant **Railway Recruitment Board undergraduate-level notifications**, if a current official notice is open and its criteria fit. These are examples to investigate, not confirmed applications, vacancies, or personal eligibility. Different posts can impose different subjects, marks, age cutoffs, typing/skill tests, medical standards, and other requirements. In particular, do not assume that every post under an examination has identical educational criteria.

Use the actual recruiting body's notice, corrigenda, and official application link. Save its examination/post name, notice number, qualification rule, age cutoff/relaxations, dates, stages, fees, and official source before making an application decision. General arithmetic, reasoning, reading comprehension, and basic general knowledge can support both this parallel track and early CSE preparation; recruitment-specific speed, typing, and question formats need separate practice. No current recruitment deadline or open vacancy has been verified here.

4. Official sources and what was checked

All URLs below are reference entry points on official domains. **Their current content was not successfully verified during this task.** Navigate from the official homepage if a deep link moves; do not infer official dates from a coaching advertisement or a search snippet.

Resource	Exact URL	Result / intended use
UPSC official homepage	https://upsc.gov.in/	Official navigation entry point; domain requests blocked by proxy.
Active examination notifications	https://upsc.gov.in/examinations/active-examinations	Requested; proxy 403. Open the Civil Services (Preliminary) examination for the intended year and download its complete notice plus corrigenda.
Examination calendar	https://upsc.gov.in/examinations/exam-calendar	Requested; proxy 403. Check the latest calendar and revisions, then the examination-specific notice.
Official previous question papers	https://upsc.gov.in/examinations/previous-question-papers	Requested; proxy 403. Obtain both Prelims papers and Mains papers; use them to identify demand and diagnose skills.
Official answer keys	https://upsc.gov.in/examinations/answer-key	Reference only; page not separately retrieved. Official keys can be published after the relevant examination process concludes. An unofficial explanation is not an official key.
NCERT textbook portal	https://ncert.nic.in/textbook.php	Requested; proxy 403. Free official textbooks; choose relevant chapters rather than buying a large collection immediately.
NCERT homepage	https://ncert.nic.in/	Requested; proxy 403. Alternative navigation into textbooks and educational resources.
ePathshala	https://epathshala.nic.in/	Requested; proxy 403. Official alternative for NCERT digital resources.

Resource	Exact URL	Result / intended use
Press Information Bureau	https://pib.gov.in/	Requested; proxy 403. Selected primary government announcements; distinguish an announcement from independent evaluation of its effects.
University Grants Commission (UGC)	https://www.ugc.gov.in/	Reference only; page not retrieved. Check the awarding institution's status and relevant official notices, then verify the programme/college details with the institution.
UGC Distance Education Bureau (UGC-DEB)	https://deb.ugc.ac.in/	Reference only; page not retrieved. For distance/online options, check recognition or entitlement for the exact institution, programme, mode, and admission session.
Staff Selection Commission (SSC)	https://ssc.gov.in/	Reference only; page not retrieved. Locate the relevant current official CHSL or other notification and check post-specific eligibility and deadlines.
Railway Recruitment Board, Chandigarh	https://www.rrbcdg.gov.in/	Reference only; page not retrieved. This is a specific regional RRB's official entry point, not a universal application portal or a verified current directory. Use its official notices/links to locate the relevant recruitment and participating board.

Alternate `www.upsc.gov.in` and `www.ncert.nic.in` hosts were also requested and blocked. No TLS, certificate, checksum, or other integrity checks were disabled.

Current calendar limitation

No 2026 or 2027 notification, calendar PDF, cutoff, vacancy count, exam date, or application date was verified. **Do not print or teach a guessed upcoming date.** Set the learner's target only after checking the latest official calendar, the intended year's notification, eligibility, and actual study capacity. Learning can start immediately while these are pending.

5. Resource use for a beginner

1. Start with short explanations and selected school-level NCERT chapters in polity, geography, history, economics, and science. Class VI–VIII material can fill gaps; Class IX–XII material can build the exam foundation. Select chapters against the syllabus and recent official questions. NCERT titles/content can change between editions.
2. Keep one main source per subject initially. Add a standard reference only after a specific gap is visible. Do not require paid coaching, a pile of books, or a newspaper subscription before the first lesson.
3. Use official previous questions early to learn what is asked. Initially solve a few with guidance; do not interpret a cold full-paper score as intelligence or final potential.
4. Maintain regular CSAT work, including basic arithmetic and passage comprehension, even while building GS knowledge.
5. Teach one concept using an everyday example, ask the learner to explain it back, ask a new application question, and revisit it later. Mark learner answers and evidence accurately; a mentor giving an explanation does not mean the learner has mastered it.

6. Introduce short written answers gradually. The eventual exam requires both recognition and written explanation.
7. For current affairs, record the source and event date. Link each useful event to a syllabus concept. Do not substitute a feed of headlines for understanding.

6. Next verification action for any future mentor

When official access is available, retrieve the latest applicable CSE notification and official calendar, save the title/year/retrieval date and exact document links, and replace the status labels above only for facts actually checked. Recheck qualification rules, age cutoff, category relaxations/attempt limits, Paper A exemptions, language rules, deadlines, and the preliminary marking instructions. Preserve the distinction between a tentative calendar date and the examination-specific final notice/corrigendum.

For the immediate college decision, gather the official prospectus, admission-session dates, fee schedule, degree/exit-award regulations, affiliation/recognition evidence, and (if relevant) the UGC-DEB programme entry. Record exact official links and the session covered. Do not mark a college or programme as verified because its marketing page says “UGC approved.” These documents can be checked separately from the UPSC study lessons; no paid admission should be inferred or undertaken without the learner's specific choice and authorisation.